

MEN'S SKINNY-FAT

VEGAN SHRED

MEAL PLANS



**Quick
Start Guide**



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My Journey

For most of my 20s, I was far from resembling the guy on the cover of this Quick Start Guide. My skinny-fat physique resulted from excessive cardio, minimal structured weight training, inadequate protein intake, and a complete disregard for tracking calories and macronutrients (protein, carbs, and fats). I was also working a brutal night shift roster and believed I was 'genetically cursed.'

Here's what my 20s were like:



After wasting my 20s (and money) on fitness magazines, fad diets, silly ab workout routines, and buying into fat burners promoted by substance-enhanced fitness influencers, I finally had enough. I decided to study the simple science of training and nutrition to see if an ordinary guy like me, with "cursed" genetics, could get completely shredded using principles grounded in science.

When I turned 30, my quest to transform my skinny-fat body began with a *shred phase*. I calculated my calorie and macronutrient targets ([here](#)) and built a meal plan around 2,200 calories, with protein set at 0.8 grams per pound of body weight per day.

The exact meal plan I developed for my shred is included in the [men's shred meal plan package](#)!

I prepped my meals twice a week and made sure to stay within 50-100 calories of my target, shedding 0.5 to 1 pound of body weight per week. I tracked this progress [using a spreadsheet you can access here](#).

If my shred slowed down to less than 0.5 pounds per week, I reduced my calorie target by a few hundred calories to maintain at least 1,800-1,900 calories per day, never dropping below 1,800 calories. I did a maximum of 2 hours of cardio a week and followed a Push Pull Legs system ([learn more here](#)). All of this was done while managing a brutal night shift roster.

This was the result of my very first skinny-fat shred.



When I completed my shred in December 2014 (see above), I wasn't satisfied with my physique since I had no muscle on my frame. Quite honestly, I was disappointed! So, I decided to lean bulk ([view plans here](#)) for as long as possible to build as much muscle as possible.

Despite working night shifts, I trained 5 days a week on a Push Pull Legs system ([learn more here](#)) for 11 months, constantly reminding myself to *trust... the... process*.

After reaching a "fluffy" 16-17% body fat, it was time to shred again. I spent another 11 months shredding, revealing a level of muscle I had only dreamt of. This transformation led me to compete in my first amateur bodybuilding competition, where I won first place!



I was 32 years old when I completed my transformation! I never used any performance-enhancing drugs and, at the time of writing this, I still haven't touched any chemicals. Since my transformation, I've launched two YouTube channels ([here](#) and [here](#)) and a coaching business ([here](#)), where I help skinny-fat guys achieve the body of their dreams.

I also developed a program called [Ultimate Body Transformation](#), with over 21,000 people enrolled and over 1,000 successful transformations using the simple system I implemented to get into the best shape of my life.

My transformation has been one of the most life-changing experiences I've ever had. It's boosted my self-confidence and self-esteem, and I feel a million times fitter and stronger than when I was in my 20s!

Now it's your turn! Choose a meal plan template, go shopping and do meal prep, and follow this Quick Start Guide and Frequently Asked Questions as closely as possible. Feel free to [share your transformation with me](#)—I'd love to hear your story.



Step 1

Buy Supplies

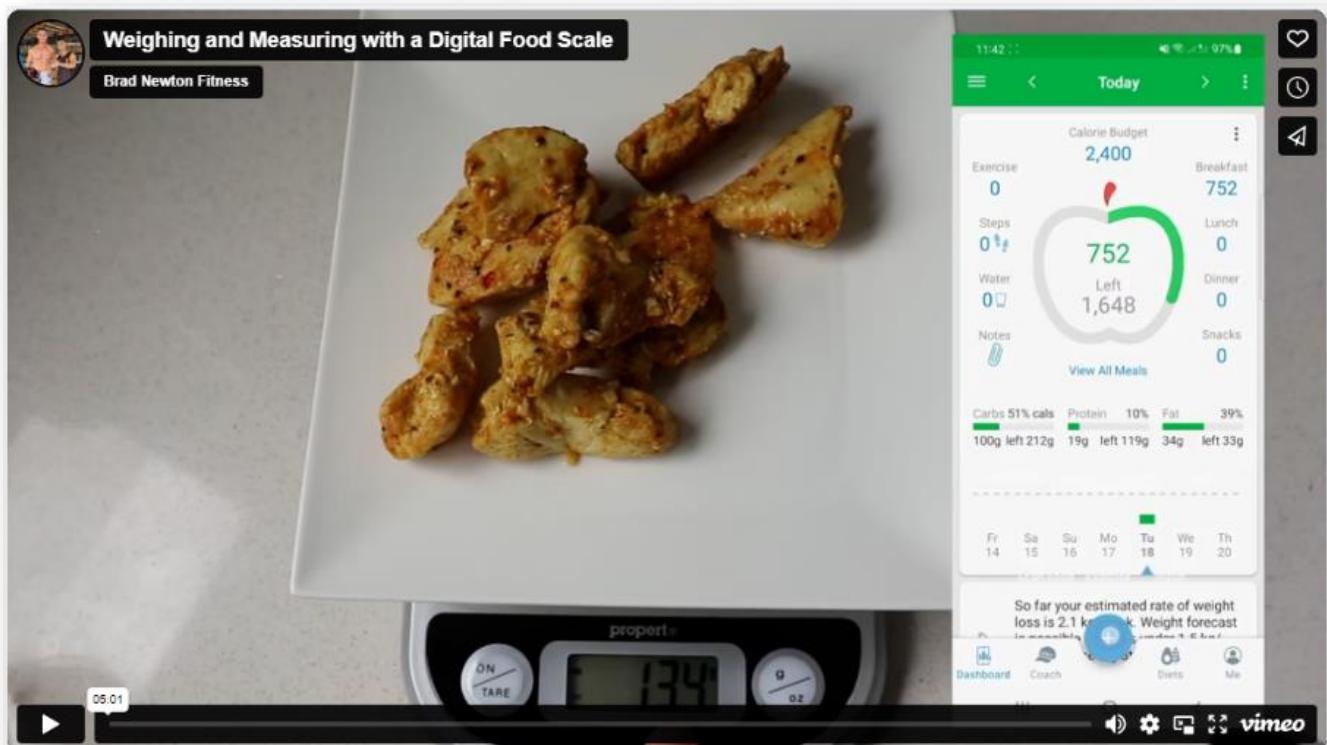
The first task after selecting a meal plan from the 10-pack is shopping for basic supplies. These essentials will make meal prepping and tracking your progress much easier, ensuring you get the best results from your meal plan.

Digital Food Scales

One of the keys to success with your meal plan is measuring out ingredients before you cook them, and a simple, reliable, and accurate digital food scale is essential for this. *Yes, you need to measure and weigh everything!*

Before you start prepping your first week's meals, take some time to familiarise yourself with the basic functions of your digital food scale, such as switching between units and taring.

In the video below, I will show you how to use a digital food scale to meal prep like a pro! (Click on the thumbnail to watch).



Suggested Digital Food Scales to Buy:

- ▣ [Great Goods High-Capacity Scale](#)
- ▣ [Accuweight 201 Scales](#)

Meal Prep Containers

Do a quick Google search for “reusable meal prep containers,” and you’ll find a ton of options. While any will do, it’s best to choose ones that are BPA-free and microwave safe. It’s also convenient if they have transparent lids and extra compartments for sides or sauces. Since I worked a lot of night shift, I prepared all my meals in microwave-friendly containers that I could easily re-heat at the office in the early hours of the morning.

Here's what my meal prep scene looked like for lean bulking ([view plans here](#)) before starting night shift. There’s a lot of brown rice there! 😊



If your plan includes food like soups, salads, fruit parfaits, and overnight oats, you might want to pick up some 12-, 16-, or 32-ounce glass [Mason jars](#) as well.



Suggested Meal Prep Containers:

- ▣ [50-Pack Meal Prep Plastic Microwavable Food Containers](#)
- ▣ [EZ Prepa \[20 Pack\] 32oz 3 Compartment Meal Prep Containers](#)
- ▣ [SimpleHouseware 3 Compartment Meal Prep containers](#)

Digital Bathroom Scales

Regularly tracking your body weight is one of the most effective ways to monitor your progress, so investing in a reliable bathroom scale is essential.

Obsessing over *daily* changes in your weight can drive you insane while on a lean bulk or shred, as these changes often have nothing to do with gaining or losing fat or muscle. Slight fluctuations in fluid retention, glycogen levels, and bowel movements can produce noticeable ups and downs.

A much better approach is to focus on the weekly average weight change, which is less erratic and better reflect changes in fat and muscle. If your averages are moving down over the course of weeks and months, you're clearly losing weight. If they're moving up, you're gaining weight.

Personally, I tracked my daily weigh-ins using training and measurement software ([click here to access](#)) and observed the changes in my weekly average weight.

For *shredding*, I aimed for a weekly weight loss of 0.5 to 1 pound. If my weight loss dropped below 0.5 pounds per week, I reduced my calorie intake by a few hundred calories.

For *lean bulking*, I set a target of gaining 0.5 to 1 pound per week. If my weight gain slowed, I increased my daily calorie intake by 100 calories. If the gain was too fast, I reduced my intake by 100 calories.

This method of tracking keeps you focused on the bigger picture instead of stressing over meaningless day-to-day variances, which can cause unnecessary frustration and confusion.



The bathroom scale is just one tool in your arsenal for collecting quantitative data on changes to your body weight. It should be used in conjunction with other measurements to get a comprehensive view of your transformation.

How to Weigh Yourself

Weigh yourself under the same conditions each day:

- First thing in the morning
- After using the bathroom
- Before eating or drinking
- Before training
- With minimal clothing

Use the training and measurements tracking software ([access here](#)) to input all of your daily weigh-ins, and it will automatically calculate your weekly average weight change.

By tracking averages over time, you'll see if you're moving in the right direction. I suggest weighing yourself at least 4 to 5 times per week during your lean bulk or shred.

Below is an example from a [coaching client](#) who tracked their fluctuating daily weight. Despite daily variations, their average weekly weight changes consistently decreased from week to week. I focus on the *trend* in the weekly average (increasing for a bulk or decreasing for a cut) rather than daily fluctuations.

	Week	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Average Weekly Weight	Weight Change
1	13-Nov-2023		166.4	167.0	166.2		166.6		166.6	-0.95
2	20-Nov-2023	167.4	166.6	166.8	165.8	167.6	167.4	166.6	166.9	0.34
3	27-Nov-2023	165.6	165.6	165.2	165.6	165.4	165.6	164.8	165.4	-1.15
4	4-Dec-2023	164.6	163.8	163.6	162.0	163.0	162.8	162.6	163.2	-2.20
5	11-Dec-2023	163.0	162.6	162.6	161.6	161.6	160.4	160.6	161.8	-3.63
6	18-Dec-2023	160.0	160.8	159.6	160.0	159.2	159.8	159.8	159.9	-1.89
7	25-Dec-2023	160.4	160.6	160.4			159.4	159.0	160.0	-1.81
8	1-Jan-2024	157.8	157.8	157.4	157.6	157.4	157.2	157.6	157.5	-2.42
9	8-Jan-2024	158.4	157.0						157.7	-2.26

Body Fat Callipers

Estimating body fat percentage from calliper measurements can be unreliable, but the measurements themselves are still valuable. If your skinfold becomes thicker over time, it indicates fat gain. Conversely, if it becomes thinner, it suggests fat loss. This information is all you really need to gauge changes in your body fat percentage.

Below is an example where I'm using the [Accu-Measure Body Fat Calliper](#) to measure my body fat percentage.



Suggested Body Fat Calliper:

- ▣ [Accu-Measure Body Fat Calliper](#)



Body Measuring Tape

Taking regular body measurements will give you a valuable insight into how your body is changing over time, and all you need is a simple measuring tape.

Suggested Body Measuring Tape:

- ▣ [MyoTape Body Measure Tape](#)

Sports Supplements

Supplements don't build great physiques—dedication to proper training and nutrition does.

Unfortunately, the workout supplement industry is rife with pseudoscience, ridiculous hype, misleading advertising and endorsements, products full of junk ingredients, underdosed key ingredients, and many other shenanigans. Most supplement companies produce cheap, subpar products and try to dazzle you with extravagant marketing claims, high-profile endorsements, pseudo-scientific jargon, fancy-sounding proprietary blends, and flashy packaging.

While workout supplements aren't essential for building muscle and losing fat, and many are a complete waste of money, the right ones can help. There are safe, natural substances that have been scientifically proven to deliver benefits such as increased strength, muscle endurance and growth, fat loss, and more.

Suggested Supplements:

- ▣ **Creatine Monohydrate**

Most supplements that claim to boost muscle growth and recovery are a letdown, but not creatine—the most researched molecule in all of sports nutrition.

Creatine is made up of several amino acids (L-arginine, glycine, and methionine) and acts as an energy reserve in most of our cells. Our bodies produce small amounts of creatine, and it's also found in foods like meat, eggs, and fish.



[Hundreds of studies](#) have shown that creatine enhances muscle and strength gain, anaerobic endurance, and post-workout recovery. Plus, it does these things safely.

Research shows that creatine isn't harmful to the kidneys, as is sometimes claimed, even for those with impaired kidney function. However, if you have any kidney issues, it's wise to speak with your doctor before taking creatine.

Creatine comes in many forms, including creatine monohydrate, buffered creatine, creatine hydrochloride, and others. But to cut to the chase: powdered *creatine monohydrate* is the most researched and time-proven form. If you find regular creatine monohydrate too grainy, opt for a micronized monohydrate powder.

The benefits of creatine are clear:

- ▣ [It helps you build muscle faster](#)
- ▣ [It helps you get stronger faster](#)
- ▣ [It improves anaerobic endurance](#)
- ▣ [It improves muscle recovery](#)

And the best part is it [does all these things naturally and safely](#).

When it comes to improving body composition and workout performance, creatine is basically all pros and no cons.

I personally use [Optimum Nutrition Creatine Monohydrate](#). I add 5 grams of this to my protein shake every day and have been doing this for almost 10 years.

Studies show that 0.02 grams per pound of body weight (3-to-5 grams for most men) of creatine monohydrate once per day is effective. While some people recommend taking upward of 20 grams per day for the first week or so ("loading phase"), this only helps you benefit from creatine faster (but not more) and it can upset your stomach, so I generally don't recommend it.

You can take creatine whenever to good effect. You don't need to take it with carbs or protein or after your workout, as some people recommend.

■ Plant-based Protein Powder



The two main touchstones you should use to judge a plant-based protein powder are as follows:

1. Its amino acid profile
2. Its digestibility

To understand the importance of these two criteria, you first must understand a little about what protein is and why it's important.

Protein is a compound composed of chains of smaller molecules known as amino acids, which are the basic building blocks of every cell in your body. When you eat protein, your body breaks it down into amino acids, which are then absorbed and used to create new protein molecules.

Your body can mix and match many amino acids to make the proteins it needs, but it must get nine amino acids from the foods you eat.

These are known as essential amino acids (EAAs), because they must be obtained from the diet.



A protein's amino acid profile is a breakdown of how much of each type of amino acid it contains.

Some proteins contain far more of certain amino acids than others, which makes them better or worse for building muscle.

Namely, proteins that have higher amounts of essential amino acids, and especially leucine, isoleucine, and valine (known as branched-chain amino acids or BCAAs), [stimulate](#) more muscle growth than those with less. [Research](#) also shows that leucine seems to be particularly effective for stimulating muscle growth, although it's probably ideal to [consume it](#) with isoleucine and valine.

So, generally, the best plant-based protein powders are going to have more essential amino acids (and especially BCAAs) than others.

The next criteria to consider is how well a plant-based protein powder is digested, absorbed, and processed by the body.

The easier it is for your body to digest, absorb, and process a protein, the better it's going to be for building muscle and improving health.

More specifically, protein digestibility refers to the percentage of protein in a food that your body absorbs and uses. For example, if you eat 30 grams of protein and your body ultimately absorbs 27 grams, then that food has a protein digestibility rating of 90%.

Thus, the higher the digestibility score, the better the protein is for building muscle.

And unfortunately for vegetarians, vegans, and those who eschew animal protein, plant-based protein powders (and proteins in general) [have](#) a protein digestibility score about 10% lower than animal foods on average.

For example, meat and fish [clock in](#) around 95%, whereas whole wheat bread [is closer](#) to 40%, and rice [comes in](#) at about 60% (the exact percentages can vary depending on the measurement method, but these are good ballpark figures).

Now, if you get protein from a variety of plant and animal sources, you'll still be able to consume enough essential amino acids to cover your nutritional bases.

If you get your protein exclusively or primarily from plant sources, however, it's easy to [fall short](#) of your essential amino acid needs. This is one of the reasons omnivores tend to have [more muscle mass](#)—they usually [eat and absorb](#) more high-quality protein than vegans or vegetarians.

The good news is that if you eat the right combination of different plant proteins, you can still meet your essential amino acid needs and build muscle just as effectively as meat-eaters.

In addition to a plant-based protein's amino acid profile and digestibility, you may also want to consider its micro nutritional value. That is, does it contain any other nutrients, in addition to essential amino acids?

Although you don't want to rely on any kind of supplement (protein powder or otherwise) as a primary source of nutrition, if one kind of plant-based protein powder provides more micronutrients than another, why not choose that one? Every little bit helps, after all.

The 3 Best Plant-Based Proteins for Building Muscle



As you're no doubt aware, there are a zillion different plant-based protein powders on the market, with some of the most popular options being soy, hemp, pea, rice, and quinoa protein powder.

Instead of going into the particulars of every protein powder, I'll save you some time and spoil the ending for you.

The three best plant-based protein powders for building muscle are . . .



1. Pea protein powder
2. Rice protein powder
3. Quinoa protein powder

Well, it just so happens that pea and rice protein powders have a complementary amino acid ratio—pea protein is high in *lysine* and rice protein is high in *methionine*.

When you combine them together, the result looks a lot like whey protein. This is why the blend of the two is often called the “vegan’s whey.”

Thus, a blend of pea and rice protein tends to produce the absolute best plant-based protein powder, because it . . .

- Has an excellent amino acid profile jam-packed with essential and branch-chain amino acids
- Is easily digested, absorbed, and processed, so the amino acids can be easily used to build and repair muscle
- Has a mild, nutty flavour (thanks primarily to the rice protein)
- Is high in micronutrients like magnesium, manganese, iron, and zinc

The problem with most plant-based protein powders, however—even pea and rice blends—is that they either taste like burned wallet, go down like quicksand, or contain too little protein per serving (usually because they contain a bunch of “filler” ingredients to goose profit margins).

Here are some of my favourite plant-based protein powder brands (not sponsored):

- ▣ [Optimum Nutrition Plant Protein](#)
- ▣ [Macro Mike Plant Protein](#)
- ▣ [Happy Way Vegan Protein](#)
- ▣ [Prana ON Power Plant Protein](#)

To wrap it up, the best plant-based protein powders are all going to have a few things in common:

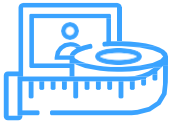
- An excellent amino acid profile with an abundance of essential amino acids
- High digestibility so the amino acids are easily used by the body
- A decent amount of micronutrients
- A pleasant taste and texture



Using these criteria, the best plant-based protein powders are pea, rice, and quinoa protein.

Although all three of these plant proteins score similarly well when it comes to their amino acid profiles, quinoa protein isn't quite as easy to digest and tends to have a gritty, unpleasant texture.

When you put all these factors together, a high-quality blend of pea and rice protein is the best plant-based protein powder.



Step 2

Take Measurements and Pictures

Tracking your body composition is a vital part of your fitness journey.

Learning to measure body composition properly will help you understand exactly what is or isn't happening with your physique, which can help you take corrective actions with your diet and exercise if you're not progressing as you'd like.

This step is crucial and failing to do this will guarantee you'll fail.

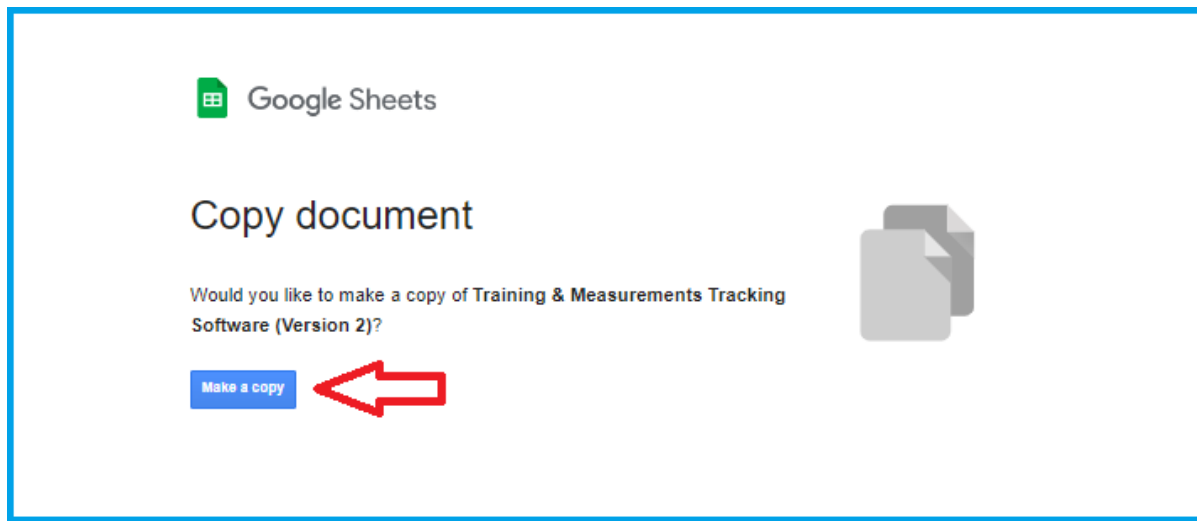
1 Weigh yourself daily and calculate weekly averages

The process is simple:

- ▣ Step on the scale first thing in the morning, wearing minimal clothing, after using the bathroom, and before consuming food, beverages, or engaging in any physical training.
- ▣ Afterward, at the end of each seven-day period, sum up your last seven weigh-ins and divide the total by seven to determine your average daily weight for the preceding week.
- ▣ Document your averages in a readily accessible location, such as Excel, Google Sheets, or the notepad application on your phone.

I've made available, for free, a [training and measurements tracking software](#) that you can "copy" across to your Google Drive and record your daily weigh-ins.

You'll need to download the software ([click here](#)) by copying it to your Google Drive. The software is a Google Sheet, and **you must** use a computer or laptop to "make a copy" of it **before** you can access it on your Android or iOS device. When you click on the link, you will see a screen (as below):



[CLICK HERE TO COPY THE TRAINING AND MEASUREMENTS TRACKING SOFTWARE](#)

By strictly adhering to these flexible meal plans, you can anticipate an average *weekly* weight reduction of approximately 0.5 to 1.5 pounds of body weight.

2 Take weekly body measurements

Relying solely on weighing yourself can't accurately indicate whether you're gaining or losing fat—it merely reflects overall weight changes. That's why it's important to regularly track at least *one* additional body measurement each week—your ***waist circumference***.

To measure your waist circumference:

- ❑ Wrap a tape measure around your bare stomach at your navel (strive to measure at the same spot each time). You can buy a cheap tape measure from [here](#).
- ❑ Ensure the tape measure is parallel to the ground (not tilted) and snug against your body, avoiding excessive tightness that might compress the skin.

- ▣ Exhale naturally while taking the measurement and maintain a relaxed posture without flexing or sucking in your stomach.

Here's an example of me taking waist measurements using a tape measure around the navel area (at or near the belly button).



My training and measurements software ([download from here](#)) will allow you to enter in your measurements every week. See screenshot below.

MEASUREMENTS TRACKER									SELF CHECK-IN NOTES	
Target Calories	Waist	Hip	OPTIONAL						(i.e., what happened during the week?)	
			Neck	Chest	Thigh	Bicep	Calf	Estimated BF %		
2100	93.0	85.0	93.0	85.0	93.0	93.0	85.0	27.0	Felt great, strong in the gym and love the new training plan	

If you enjoy monitoring data and quantifying progress like me, you can also measure other body parts such as your chest, neck, thigh, biceps, and calves.

3 Take monthly body fat measurements

To get an even better understanding of how your body composition is changing, use a body fat calliper to take skinfold measurements every month and record the results inside of [my training and measurements tracking software](#).



4 Take bi-weekly progress pictures

While numerical data from measurements is valuable, our primary concern lies in the visual changes we observe in the mirror. That's why regularly capturing progress pictures is crucial—they provide a visual timeline of your transformation. Here's how to do it effectively:

- ▣ Take pictures from the front, side, and back, revealing as much skin as you're comfortable with (optimal exposure enhances the clarity of body changes).
- ▣ Ensure consistency by using the same camera, lighting, and background for all photos.
- ▣ Take the pictures at the same time every day, preferably in the morning, after using the bathroom and before breakfast.
- ▣ Take both flexed and unflexed pictures, as this lets you see how your muscles are developing.
- ▣ Double check each picture to make sure they're clear and free from any glare or shadow that might make it difficult to see your body.



Step 3

Prepare Your Meals

1 Pick a day to prepare all your meals for the coming week

Preparing your food on Sunday is effective for several reasons: it doesn't interfere with your weekend activities, it helps keep your meals fresh throughout the week, and since many people start their meal plans on Monday, it ensures you're ready to go when you want to begin.

2 Get rid of food that might tempt you

Throw away all the junk food that's in your house, but not on your plan, and if possible, do the same at work.

3 Go grocery shopping

Only buy what's on your list and nothing else. The shopping list that comes with your plan has quantities measured out in 1-, 5-, 6- and 7-day meal prep options. Pick which one works best for you.

4 Cook your meals

Clean any tools or surfaces you'll need to prepare your meals (knives, countertops, pans, etc.). Wash and chop all the food you're going to cook. Cook all your meals and store them in containers.

5 Prevent “mindless eating” with “micro-portioning”

When you have a big bag of snacks, treats, or calorie-dense foods in your lap, it can be hard to stop eating. Sort foods you'll be tempted to overeat (nuts, dried fruit, chocolate, etc.) into single portions and store them in smaller containers or bags. Pill bags (like [these](#)) or plastic cups with lids (like [these](#)) work well.

Congratulations, now you're ready to start!

- **Follow the meal plan exactly.** This means no random substitutions (you can make substitutions, but make sure you measure and track the food items and match the total daily calorie and macro targets given at the bottom of the plans), no under- or overeating, and no sneaking extra snacks, condiments, or treats.
- **Read the FAQ** that comes with your meal plans.
- **Watch your body change** and share your transformation with me 😊

Lastly, you really need to *trust the process*. This means having faith in the method and its effectiveness to yield incredible results. There will be times when you'll need to go on a work trip, take a vacation, dine out, or go "off the meal plan" for a few days or even a week. Just get back on track as soon as possible and keep moving forward. You'll get there eventually.

I achieved my entire transformation while working an insane night shift roster. All my bodybuilding competitions were undertaken around the same schedule! If I, an ordinary guy from Melbourne, can achieve such incredible results without any performance-enhancing drugs, then I'm confident that you can too!

If you ever run into any problems along the way, just shoot me an email at brad@bradnewtonfitness.com, and I'll be here to help. If you need one-on-one coaching, [let me know](#).

